Macapado A. Muslim

Macapado Abaton Muslim (born July 4, 1956) is a Filipino political scientist, public administrator, and peacebuilding scholar from Marawi City, Lanao del Sur—the heartland of the Meranaw people. Over more than four decades, he built one of the most distinctive careers in Mindanao's academic and governance landscape: a scholar who refused to stay in the ivory tower, and an administrator who never stopped thinking like a researcher. As the 6th Regular President of the Mindanao State University (MSU) System, he modernized an eleven-campus institution while simultaneously producing a body of work that helped reshape how the Philippine government and the broader academic world understand the Bangsamoro struggle. His most enduring intellectual contribution—the theory of **Autonomy Plus Compensatory Justice**—gave peacebuilders a framework that went beyond simply drawing lines on a map, insisting instead that political self-governance must be paired with a serious reckoning for decades of historical injustice. That idea didn't just stay in his books; it found its way into the structural logic of the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM).

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Early Life and Cultural Background

Macapado Muslim was born and raised in Marawi City, a city that sits at the edge of Lake Lanao and carries the weight of centuries of Meranaw identity, Islamic tradition, and colonial resistance. Growing up in the post-independence Philippines of the late 1950s and 1960s, he came of age during a time when Moro consciousness was beginning to find political shape—when the grievances of Bangsamoro communities, long simmering under colonial and post-colonial governance, were edging toward open conflict.

That environment shaped his thinking from the start. Unlike analysts who studied the so-called "Moro Problem" from a comfortable distance in Manila, Muslim was an insider. He wasn't reading about displacement and marginalization in academic journals—he was living in a community that embodied both the richness of Meranaw culture and the real consequences of institutional neglect. Rather than pushing him toward radicalism, this proximity to conflict convinced him early on that education and political engineering were the most powerful tools available for lasting change.

His faith as a Muslim in the Philippine south also anchored his later thinking on governance. He would eventually articulate a philosophy of "moral governance"—a vision of public administration grounded in Islamic ethical principles—that grew directly from his upbringing in a city where religion, culture, and politics were never separate conversations.

Education

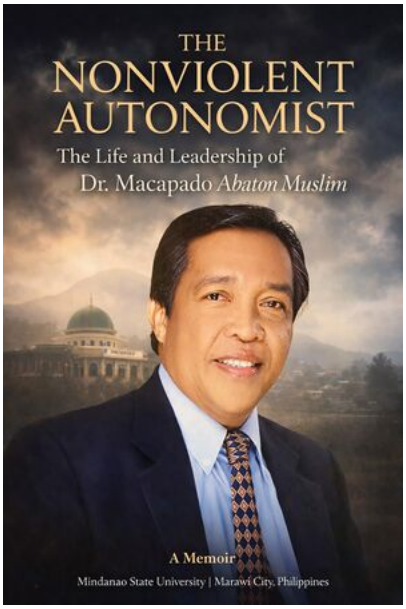
Undergraduate Studies at MSU

Muslim completed his Bachelor of Science at Mindanao State University in Marawi City—the same institution he would one day lead. Founded explicitly as a "laboratory for peace" and social integration in Mindanao, MSU shaped his conviction that universities aren't just places for producing graduates; they're institutions with a civic mission in divided societies.

Master of Public Administration, UP Diliman

After finishing at MSU, he moved to Quezon City to pursue a Master of Public Administration (MPA) at the University of the Philippines Diliman's National College of Public Administration and Governance

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Born	July 4, 1956 Marawi City, Lanao del Sur, Philippines
Nationality	Filipino
Ethnicity	Meranaw
Alma mater	Mindanao State University (BS) University of the Philippines Diliman (MPA, 1980) University of Hawaii at Manoa (MA, PhD, 1990)
Known for	"Autonomy Plus Compensatory Justice" theory; 6th Regular President, Mindanao State University System
Title	University Professor (Emeritus)
Positions held	Dean, College of Public Affairs, MSU-Marawi (1991–1994) Chancellor, MSU-General Santos (1995–2007) Acting President, MSU System (2008–2010) President, MSU System (2010–2016)
Awards	Vice President, Philippine Political Science

(NCPAG), completing the degree in 1980. The UP Diliman years gave him a precise understanding of how the Philippine state works—and, critically, where and why it fails. Those failures, he would argue throughout his career, were not accidental; they were structural, and they had everything to do with the marginalization of minority communities in the country's south.

	Association; Vice President, Philippine Society for Public Administration; Vice President, East-West Center Alumni Association – Philippines
Field	Political Science, Public Administration, Peacebuilding

Doctoral Studies at the University of Hawaii

The most formative chapter of his intellectual life unfolded in Honolulu, Hawaii. As an East-West Center scholar—a prestigious program that brings together researchers from across the Asia-Pacific—he enrolled at the University of Hawaii at Manoa, where he earned both a Master of Arts and a Doctor of Philosophy in Political Science, completing his doctorate in 1990.

At the University of Hawaii, he worked under the mentorship of the late **Dr. Glenn Paige**, a pioneering figure in political science who founded the Center for Global Nonviolence and developed the field of "nonkilling" political theory. Paige's influence was lasting. Muslim would go on to become a long-standing associate of the Center for Global Nonviolence, and Paige's insistence on the moral and strategic superiority of nonviolent political solutions runs through virtually everything Muslim has written and done.

His doctoral dissertation, *The Moro Armed Struggle in the Philippines: The Nonviolent Autonomy Alternative*, became the foundational text of his career—a rigorous, deeply personal argument that the Moro conflict was not a security problem to be managed militarily, but a political problem demanding a political and constitutional solution.

Summary of Academic Credentials

Degree	Institution	Year
Bachelor of Science	Mindanao State University, Marawi City	*N/A*
Master of Public Administration (MPA)	University of the Philippines Diliman (NCPAG)	1980
Master of Arts, Political Science	University of Hawaii at Manoa	*N/A*
Doctor of Philosophy (PhD), Political Science	University of Hawaii at Manoa	1990

Career

Early Academic Career at MSU

Muslim started as an Instructor at Mindanao State University in June 1980, right after finishing his MPA. He moved steadily through the ranks: Associate Professor V by January 1986, then Professor VI in January 1991 following his doctoral graduation. In March 2016, he was conferred the title of **University Professor**—the highest academic distinction in the Philippine university system, and one that's not handed out lightly. It's reserved for scholars whose records of research, publication, and service set them apart across decades of work.

Dean, College of Public Affairs (1991–1994)

From January 1991 to November 1994, Muslim served as Dean of the College of Public Affairs at MSU-Marawi. It was during this period that his major research outputs on the Moro struggle began appearing in print, laying the groundwork for the policy influence he'd later exercise at the national level. He ran the college not just as an administrative function, but as a platform for producing research with real-world consequence.

Campus Chancellor, MSU–General Santos (1995–2007)

His most telling test as a manager came during two full five-year terms as Chancellor of MSU–General Santos City, from December 1995 to March 2007. General Santos City sits in a multicultural urban landscape where ethnic and political tensions have historically made institution-building complicated. His success in nurturing an effective and peaceful campus environment in that setting established his reputation as someone who could manage complexity without sacrificing principle—a quality that would later define his MSU System presidency.

The MSU System Presidency (2008–2016)

Acting President (2008–2010)

In 2008, Muslim was designated Acting President of the MSU System after topping the selection process. His regular appointment, however, was held up for more than two years by what observers described as political maneuvering both within and outside the university. When President Gloria Macapagal-Arroyo finally signed his appointment on March 5, 2010, critics attached the "midnight appointment" label to it—but his peers pushed back firmly on that framing.

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The delay was, for many who watched it unfold, a case study in the political vulnerabilities of academic leaders in regions where governance and patronage are tangled together.

Regular President (2010–2016)

Muslim was formally installed as the **6th Regular President of the Mindanao State University System** on July 1, 2010. He led an institution spread across eleven campuses, with a mandate as old as the university itself: to serve as an instrument of peace and development in the southern Philippines.

His administration organized its work around several connected pillars:

Academic Meritocracy
: He pushed hard to insulate MSU's promotions and admissions from political patronage—a persistent problem in institutions embedded in regional power structures. Raising standards wasn't popular everywhere, but it was, in his view, non-negotiable.

Infrastructure and Equipment Build-up
: Particularly in his final years as president, Muslim prioritized large-scale infrastructure development across the campuses—new laboratories, upgraded academic buildings, modernized facilities. The goal was straightforward: an institution that aspires to be globally competitive has to look and function like one.

Income Generation

Aware that relying entirely on national government appropriations was a structural weakness, he launched income-generating initiatives through land use development and other entrepreneurial programs, giving MSU a measure of financial resilience.

Strategic Rationalization
He oversaw a review and realignment of academic programs to ensure they served the actual development needs of Mindanao and met international academic standards—not just on paper, but in practice.

Internationalization
Muslim consistently pushed for MSU to engage with the broader ASEAN region. On August 6, 2015, he hosted a major forum on Malaysian Foreign Policy and ASEAN, making the case that higher education institutions in the south have a specific role to play in regional peacebuilding and socio-economic development.

His leadership style was described by colleagues as "decisive and strategic," always oriented toward what he called the "equipoise of technology and moral-spiritual values."

Scholarly Contributions

Dissertation and First Book

Muslim's 1994 book, *The Moro Armed Struggle in the Philippines: The Nonviolent Autonomy Alternative*, published from his doctoral dissertation, is the work that established his standing as the foremost academic voice on the Moro conflict from within the Bangsamoro community itself. It drew on human needs theory and political engineering to argue that armed struggle was not an irrational impulse but a rational—if ultimately destructive—response to systemic exclusion. The solution, he argued, was also political: not suppression, but genuine structural reform.

The Theory of Autonomy Plus Compensatory Justice

The concept that defines his academic legacy is **Autonomy Plus Compensatory Justice**. It's a deceptively simple formulation that addresses one of the most common failure modes of peace agreements: granting autonomy without actually fixing the damage that made autonomy necessary in the first place.

> Political autonomy alone is insufficient to end conflict if it is not paired with compensatory justice—a massive, focused effort to undo the historical and systematic marginalization and economic destitution caused by decades of conflict and neglect.|author=Macapado A. Muslim|source=*The Moro Armed Struggle in the Philippines: The Nonviolent Autonomy Alternative* (1994)

In Muslim's framework, compensatory justice isn't charity—it's an obligation. It requires the Philippine state to channel significant resources into the autonomous region specifically because that region was impoverished through state action (or inaction) over generations. This theory offered the intellectual scaffolding for moving beyond the limited autonomy of the 1990s Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (ARMM) toward the more ambitious and better-resourced design of the BARMM.

Research Output and Current Thrusts

Over his career, Muslim published more than 60 research papers and books spanning governance reforms, political leadership, peacebuilding, and federalism. His current research focus centers on constitutional design and institutional innovation in divided and unequal societies—work that remains directly relevant as the BARMM moves toward regular parliamentary governance.

His work is among the most frequently cited in studies on the Moro conflict and post-conflict reconstruction in the Philippine south.

Policy Contributions to the National Government

Beyond publishing, Muslim has consistently offered his expertise to national governance through voluntary policy papers submitted directly to the President of the Philippines. These submissions have addressed:

- Managing the COVID-19 pandemic at the regional level, with specific frameworks for high-risk and conflict-affected areas
- Strengthening BARMM governance during its transition from an interim to a regular parliamentary government
- The role of morally upright and competent political leadership in fragile, divided societies

This willingness to translate academic work into actionable policy advice—without waiting for a formal appointment or compensation—reflects his view that scholarship carries a social responsibility, especially in communities that have historically been underserved by the state.

Legacy and Impact

The Scholar-Manager Model

Muslim's career offers what is perhaps the most fully realized example in the contemporary Philippines of the "scholar-manager" model—someone who demonstrates, through sustained practice, that rigorous academic work and effective institutional leadership aren't in tension. They reinforce each other.

Sixty-plus publications alongside the successful management of an eleven-campus university system isn't common anywhere. In a conflict-affected region with chronic resource constraints and political volatility, it's remarkable. He showed a generation of administrators at MSU and beyond that you don't have to choose between thinking carefully and acting decisively.

Moral Governance in the BARMM

His most far-reaching contribution to governance may be the influence of his thought on what the BARMM has adopted as "**Moral Governance**"—a philosophy that grounds public administration in Islamic ethical values: justice (*adl*), transparency (*amanah*), and compassion (*rahmah*). Muslim didn't invent this concept from scratch, but his decades of writing and teaching about the indispensability of morally upright leadership in divided societies gave it an academic and policy anchor.

Studies on the BARMM's education and governance reforms have found that where moral governance frameworks have been institutionalized, stakeholder trust and institutional performance have improved measurably. Muslim's fingerprints are on those frameworks, not through coercion or appointment, but through the gradual absorption of

ideas into policy culture.

Advancing the Bangsamoro Cause Internationally

Through his work at the East-West Center, his affiliations with international organizations, and his role in bringing diplomatic forums to Mindanao, Muslim helped present the Bangsamoro struggle as a legitimate question of self-determination and constitutional design—not a regional insurgency to be managed through security operations. That reframing mattered, both for international audiences and for Bangsamoro leaders themselves.

Controversies and Critical Perspectives

The Presidential Appointment Controversy

The two-year gap between his designation as Acting President and his formal appointment as Regular President remains the most discussed episode of his institutional career. His peers saw it as a political squeeze play—using bureaucratic delay to stall reforms that would reduce the influence of patronage networks. His critics, a smaller number, used the "midnight appointment" framing to question the legitimacy of the appointment itself. The weight of evidence, and the professional consensus, favored his colleagues' view: this was a qualified candidate who had been made to wait.

Critique of the Marawi Rehabilitation

After the devastating 2017 Marawi Siege left much of the city's core destroyed and tens of thousands of families displaced, Muslim became one of the loudest and most credible voices criticizing the government's reconstruction approach.

He called the proposed "New Marawi" a **pie in the sky fantasy**, a phrase that landed hard in policy circles because it came from someone with decades of credibility on Bangsamoro affairs—not from an opposition politician looking for a sound bite.

His critique had several specific threads:

- The government's reconstruction priorities favored prestige projects—cultural centers, sports complexes—over the urgent work of rebuilding homes in the Ground Zero areas
- Thousands of internally displaced persons (IDPs) had effectively become permanent displacees because residential reconstruction was crawling while infrastructure projects moved faster
- He argued that restorative rebuilding had to come first; modernization could follow once original residents were back in their homes

These were not abstract academic arguments. They were the application of his "compensatory justice" framework to a real, ongoing catastrophe—and they kept him in the public conversation long after his formal MSU tenure ended.

Awards and Professional Affiliations

Muslim's contributions have been recognized by several national and international organizations:

- **Vice President**, Philippine Political Science Association

- **Vice President**, Philippine Society for Public Administration
- **Vice President**, East-West Center Alumni Association – Philippines
- **Associate**, Center for Global Nonviolence (founded by Dr. Glenn Paige, University of Hawaii)

These affiliations span both the academic and policy dimensions of his career—political science on one side, public administration on the other, and nonviolence studies threading through both.

Personal Philosophy

Running through everything Muslim has done—his scholarship, his administration, his public criticism—is a consistent philosophical commitment: that governance is a moral act, not just a technical one. In a region where public administration has too often meant the distribution of patronage along ethnic and political lines, his insistence on merit, accountability, and ethical leadership reads as both an academic position and a personal one.

His concept of "the transformative magic of education" isn't mere rhetoric. It's the animating conviction of a man who grew up in a community at the center of a protracted conflict and chose to spend his life building institutions rather than fighting battles.

See Also

- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Mindanao State University
- Moro conflict
- Marawi City
- Lanao del Sur
- Meranaw people
- Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- 2017 Marawi Siege
- East-West Center
- Bangsamoro Organic Law
- Glenn Paige
- Center for Global Nonviolence

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External Links

- Mindanao State University – Official Website (http://www.msumarawi.edu.ph)
- East-West Center – Official Website (http://www.eastwestcenter.org)
- Center for Global Nonviolence – Official Website (http://www.nonkilling.org)

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